

scholarships add up: “They go really far toward knocking out that student debt you don’t have to pay down the road.”

Berman streamlined the application process. He found applying for most scholarships required writing an essay. However, most revolved around the same five themes.

1. Why did you select your major?
2. What are your future goals?
3. What is your biggest failure and what did you learn from that experience?
4. Why do you deserve this scholarship?
5. What is your greatest accomplishment?

He invested time to write strong essays around each of these themes, then he applied for many scholarships, taking just a few minutes each time to fine tune the template essay, customizing it for the scholarship he was applying to.

It paid off. Berman reports that he was able to obtain grants and scholarships totaling between \$15,000 and \$20,000 each year. Combined with other strategies, he reduced the \$30,000 annual sticker price at his college to between \$5,000 and \$7,000 per year.